

it is nearby you can communicate with it by speaking aloud, and you, but only you, can hear its whispers.

☉☉☉☉ Your spirit companion is a very important spirit, perhaps even known to mortal shamans. You can speak to the spirit mentally as long as it is nearby. You can see through its eyes and it can see through yours. It can store six extra points of Willpower or Medicine for you in any combination. It always knows where you are, can look in on you at any time, and can even assume material form in the Middle Realm, for short periods of time.

☉☉☉☉☉ Your companion is a major presence in the spirit realm, such as the herald of Thunderbird or a lesser manifestation of Blue Corn Woman. You can speak mentally to the spirit no matter where it is, and you always know each other's location. You both share all five senses and can even share Arts and other special abilities. It can store eight extra points of Willpower or Medicine in any combination. It can assume physical form in the Middle Realm whenever you or it desires and can remain there until you wish it to leave or until it is banished.

Totem

Totem is your spiritual link with a spirit with a particular plant, rock, or body of water. Connection to a totem spirit is necessary for entry into the spirit realm, so most Nunnehi possess at least one level of the Totem Background. Those who do not have a Totem cannot enter the spirit realm unless brought there by a Nunnehi who does have Totem.

Totem spirits can also grant certain bonuses to Traits and Advantages. The number of points spent on the Totem Background reflects the relative power of the Totem and the strength of the bonuses granted. (See the sections on Totems and Entering the Spirit Plane for further information on how to use this Background.)

- ☉ You are linked to a small totem spirit.
- ☉☉ You are linked with a totem spirit of some small power.
- ☉☉☉ You are linked with a moderately powerful totem spirit.
- ☉☉☉☉ You are linked with a significantly powerful totem spirit.
- ☉☉☉☉☉ You are linked with an extremely powerful totem spirit.

Vision

You are able to access the Higher Hunting Grounds, through chanting and meditation. Through these visions, you connect with past incarnations of yourself and sometimes other Nunnehi or Native Americans.

Any time the character wishes to learn something of the past, the player may roll a number of dice equal to her Vision rating (difficulty 6). The number of successes determines the clarity and usefulness of the vision.

The method of attempting a Vision is different for each Nunnehi, but it always involves a ritual of some kind that takes at least one minute for each level of Vision attempted. Storytellers may also choose to have a character experience a

spontaneous vision if it suits the story. Additional people may be allowed to take part in the ritual, and thus be able to witness the vision, but the difficulty is increased by one for each additional participant. Though a vision may, at times, allow the Nunnehi to witness or even interact with people of the past, the past is *never* affected in any way.

- ☉ Your visions are, at best, hazy and unclear flashes of the past. They may even be false.
- ☉☉ Your visions are clearer and usually accurate. They may last for several seconds.
- ☉☉☉ You are able to learn worthwhile lore and history from visions that may last a full minute.
- ☉☉☉☉ Your visions may reveal important information. Past events are witnessed with remarkable clarity that many last for several minutes.
- ☉☉☉☉☉ Your visions may become full vision quests where you are able to ask questions of people or spirits of the past. This experience may last for an hour or even more.

Totems

The Nunnehi have close ties to the spirit world, and many of them have a Totem spirit. The Storyteller should feel free to create her own Totems, as can players with the Storyteller's permission. Nunnehi can also choose from the Menehune totems listed later in this chapter.

Birch

Background Cost: 2

Birch can be found in cooler climates, and is found in abundance in the northern and northwestern parts of America and Canada. Her paper-white bark is stretched over canoe frames, and oil extracted from the bark has great medicinal value. Birch is tall and stately, proud of her beauty and grace.

Traits: Birch grants her Nunnehi children an additional dot of Charisma and a dot of the Medicine Ability.

Taboo: Birch asks her children to protect her forests from overuse.

Cottonwood

Background Cost: 5

Cottonwood grows on the American prairie, and reaches heights of 80 to 100 feet. She is extremely fast growing, and provides a welcoming source of shade on the hot prairies. Long ago, she taught the Sioux how to build their tipis, and later her wood was used by European settlers to build their own houses. Most importantly, cottonwood is used as the center pole for the rigorous sun dance, one of the most important ceremonies of several Native American tribes, including the Sioux and the Crow. Cottonwood is one of the most spiritual trees, and regards herself as the caretaker of the land.

Traits: Cottonwood grants her children 2 points of Greymayre and 2 points of Craft (woodcarving). In addition, Nunnehi who complete the strenuous sun dance ceremony also gain an additional point of Stamina that lasts for a full year. The